The ancient Vedas were heard as ‘shrutis’ and were then remembered as ‘smritis’. The written word came much later. Mantras get energized only when they are recited in the correct rhythm and tone. Beauty is imparted and sought through arrangements of sound; imagery is not of the same order. To an Indian, Chinese music sounds stilted and limited, while Indian classical music is a breathtaking mastery of the seven notes and several microtones in between, forever reinventing itself. For these reasons, I consider Chinese culture as predominantly visual, a legacy of the ancient ideogram, while India’s is a predominantly aural culture, where the spoken word, the musical note, the sacred mantra, were to become its defining characteristics. This difference in their civilizational trajectories has had its impact on how the two cultures perceive the world around them and how they interact with one another.

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The emphasis on the written word led to an immense treasury of historical documentation in China. The Chinese pilgrims Fa Xian [2] and Xuan Zang [3] left elaborate records of their journeys to India and its great universities of Taxila, Nalanda and Vikramshila. In contrast, while it is estimated that at the beginning of the sixth century CE the number of Indian Buddhist monks and teachers in China was upwards of 3,000, no accounts of China as they perceived their adopted country have surfaced so far. Only some legends survive in temples associated with the more famous among them, such as the Shaolin temple linked with the Zen master Bodhidharma and the Fei Lai Feng temple, or the Peak that Flew Over, located in Hangzhou, associated with the Buddhist monk known only by his Chinese name, Huili. Huili came from Rajgir, capital of the ancient kingdom of Magadh in India, during the time of Lord Buddha, and chose the location of his temple at the foot of a peak that resembled the Gridhkuta (Vulture’s Peak) in his native town – hence the name Peak that Flew Over.

The great value attached to the written word, bound as it has been with Chinese aesthetics and the thought processes of a complex culture, has combined with an enormous and detailed historical record to provide a